

forms to generating dynamic Web content to sending and receiving cookies, yet there are three main areas where PHP scripts are usually deployed.

- **Server-side scripting:** This is the main usage and target area of PHP. You require a PHP parser, a Web browser and a Web server to make use of it, and then you will be able to view the PHP output of Web pages on your machine's browser.
- **Command line scripting:** PHP scripts can also be run without any server or browser but with the help of a PHP parser. This is most suited for tasks that take a lot of time—for example, sending newsletters to thousands of records, taking backups from databases, and transferring heavy files from one location to another.
- **Creating desktop applications:** PHP can also be used to develop desktop based applications with graphical user interfaces (GUI). Though it has a lot of pain points, you can use PHP-GTK for that, if you want to. PHP-GTK is available as an extension to PHP.

Fact: Did you know that PHP has a mascot just like sports teams? The PHP mascot is a big blue elephant named elePHPant.

PHP and HTML – similar but different

PHP is often confused with HTML. So to set things straight, let's take a look at how PHP and HTML are different and similar at the same time. As we all know, HTML is a markup language and is the backbone for front-end Web pages. On the other hand, PHP works in the background, on the server, where HTML is deployed to perform tasks. Together, they are used to make Web pages dynamic. For better understanding, let's look at an example where you display some content on a Web page using HTML. Now, if you want to do some back-end validation on the database, then you will use PHP to do it. So both HTML and PHP have different assigned roles and they complement each other perfectly. Listed below are some of the similarities and differences that will make this clear.

Similarities	Differences
Compatible with most of the browsers supporting their technologies.	HTML is used on the front-end whereas PHP is back-end technology.
Can be used on all operating systems.	PHP is a programming language, whereas HTML is called a markup language and is not included in the category of programming languages because it can't do calculations like '1+1=2'.

History and development

The development of PHP dates back to 1994 when a Danish-Canadian programmer Rasmus Lerdorf created Perl scripts

called 'Personal Home Page Tools' in order to maintain his personal Web pages. The succeeding year, these tools were released under the name of 'Personal Home Page/Forms Interpreter' as CGI binaries. They were enabled to provide support for databases and Web forms. Once they were released to the whole world, PHP underwent a series of developments and modifications, and the result was that the second version of 'Personal Home Page/Forms Interpreter' was released in November 1997. Moving on, PHP 3, 4 and 5 were released in 1998, 2000 and 2004, respectively.

Today, the most used version of PHP is PHP 5, with approximately 93 per cent of the websites using PHP making use of it, though PHP 7 is also available in the market. In 2010, PHP 5.4 came out with Unicode support added to it.

The pros and cons of PHP

Before going further into PHP development, let's take a look at some of the advantages and disadvantages of using it in Web development.

Advantages

- **Availability:** The biggest advantage of PHP is that it is available as open source, due to which one can find a large developer community for support and help.
- **Stability:** PHP has been in use since 1995 and thus it's quite stable compared to other server side scripting languages since its source code is open and if any bug is found, it can be readily fixed.
- **Extensive libraries:** There are thousands of libraries available which enhance the abilities of PHP—for example, PDFs, graphs, Flash movies, etc. PHP makes use of modules, so you don't have to write everything from the beginning. You just need to add the required module in your code and you are good to go.
- **Built-in modules:** Using PHP, one can connect to the database effortlessly using its built-in modules, which drastically reduce the development time and effort of Web developers.
- **Cross-platform:** PHP is supported on all platforms, so you don't have to worry whether your code written in Windows OS will work on Linux or not.
- **Easy to use:** For beginners, learning PHP is easy because of its cool syntax, which is somewhat similar to the C programming language, making it even simpler for those familiar with C.

Disadvantages

- **Not suitable for huge applications:** Though PHP has a lot of advantages in Web page development, it still can't be used to build complicated and huge Web applications since it does not support modularity and, hence, the maintenance of the app will be a cumbersome task.
- **Security:** Security of data involved in Web pages is of paramount concern. The security of PHP can be